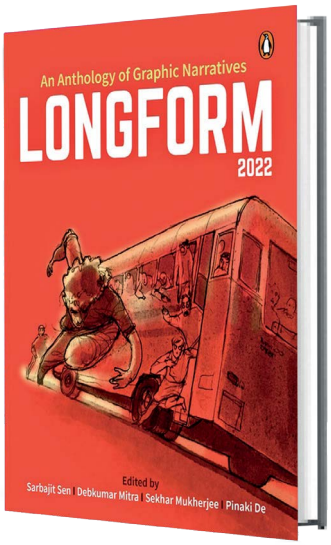
BOOKS

COMIC RELIEF

The **Comics Culture Collective** is trying to introduce Bengali comics to a larger audience







In **JANUARY, DURING A WEEKLONG** trip to Kolkata, I was pleasantly surprised to see the name of the park right opposite my hotel—Narayan Debnath Park, after the eponymous comics writer and artist. The late Debnath (1925-2022) was the creator of super-popular Bengali comic strips such as *Bantul the Great* and *Nonte Phonte*. Kolkata is arguably the only Indian metropolis that can honour comics creators this way. Which is why it was little surprise to see the sheer range and historical significance of the exhibits at *Comics in Bengal*, a recent month-long exhibition organised by the Kolkata Centre for Creativity, in association with the Comics Culture Collective.

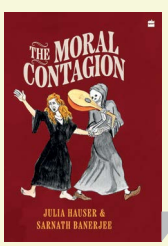
Founded during the first wave of the pandemic in 2020, the Comics Culture Collective consists of bibliophiles Biswadeb Gangopadhyay and Debasis Gupta alongside graphic designer and illustrator Pinaki De, cartoonist Rituparno Basu and collector-researcher Swagata Dutta Burman. De, who besides his comics work has created dozens of book covers for Penguin and HarperCollins down the years, teaches at the Raja Peary Mohan College in Uttarpara and is also a part of the Longform Collective, which edited/produced the English-language comics anthologies *Longform* (2018, HarperCollins) and *Longform 2022* (Penguin Random House India).

"Longform is more of a practitioner's collective," says De. "But I am also an academic and I wanted to be part of a group that catered to academic interests, the needs of scholars and researchers. During the pandemic, we first got together and started putting together old Bengali comics from the 1920s, '30s and '40s. I am coordinating our digitisation

BOOKS

DRAWING DYSTOPIAS

Three recent graphic novels that grapple with ancient and modern ills plaguing us



THE MORAL CONTAGION
by Julia Hauser and Sarnath Banerjee
HARPERCOLLINS
₹699; 140 pages

The Covid-19 pandemic may have top recall in our minds, but it is only the latest in an impressive line of plagues and pandemics that have oppressed humanity. This meticulously researched chronology of plagues by historian Julia Hauser is beautifully complemented by Sarnath Banerjee's illustrations in his distinctive style. "From sixth-century Constantinople and fourteenth century Europe to Islamic Spain, seventeenth-century London, eighteenth-century Aleppo, and Hong Kong, Bombay, San Francisco and South Africa in the late nineteenth and early twentieth centuries, the history of the plague is...the story of modern civilization" reads the jacket blurb. A morbidly fascinating book and a must-read–lest we forget.